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THE GRAND VITARA IS TASKED WITH GUIDING MARUTI SUZUKI TOWARDS SUCCESS IN THE MID-SIZE SUV SEGMENT

BY DHRUV SAXENA



Maruti Suzuki has joined hands with Toyota to take the fight to segment leaders Hyundai Creta and Kia Seltos as well as the Skoda Kushaq, VW Taigun and MG Astor. The Grand Vitara and Toyota's Hyryder might be very closely related, but Maruti Suzuki has done a fine job of giving its SUV its own identity. A flat upright bonnet coupled with a large chrome grille and neatly executed split headlamps give this SUV a contemporary yet imposing look. The rear gets very attractive LED stop lamps that extend almost across the length of the boot while the reverse lamp and indicators are mounted on the bumper.

The layout, switchgear, steering wheel—essentially every component—are shared with the Hyryder. There's a healthy list of features on offer, including a 9-inch touchscreen with wireless Android Auto and Apple CarPlay connectivity along with automatic climate control, an auto-dimming rearview mirror, electrically adjustable ORVMs, TPMS and 360-degree camera view, to name a few. Features like ventilated front seats, a head-up display, and wireless smartphone charging are reserved for the strong hybrid variant.

While the front seats are very comfortable, they can't be electrically adjusted. The quality of plastics could have been better too. The rear seat boasts generous knee room with good under-thigh support and the recline function helps further bolster the comfort quotient. The headroom is just about adequate, though.

Maruti Suzuki Grand Vitara Alpha+
Engine 1.5 petrol hybrid
Power 115.56bhp
Gearbox e-CVT
Price Rs 19.49 lakh (ex-showroom)



With a combined system output of almost 116bhp, the hybrid variant is fairly quick off the line. A claimed figure of 27.97kmpl combined with a 45-litre fuel tank theoretically translates to a range in excess of 1,200km. Its ride quality feels very European in the sense that it is on the harsher side at low speeds, but improves significantly as speeds rise and the SUV feels very well tied down to the road at triple-digit speeds.

The Grand Vitara has plenty going for it, including contemporary looks, a long list of features, impressive handling, efficient powertrains and the peace of mind that comes with owning a Maruti Suzuki. It looks set to take a substantial chunk of buyers away from the established rivals. ■